fifth centuries BCE, new cities had arisen across the Gangetic Plain. New trades and lifestyles had emerged. Kingships coexisted with nascent democratic republics, which, like Athens later on, did not survive the march of monarchy and empire.[3]

In these new cities, people were debating some very bold and original questions: What is the nature of reality and how do we know it? Where does consciousness come from? Are virtue and vice absolute or mere social conventions? Wandering philosophers thrived in a marketplace of ideas. These included radical materialists, chronic fatalists, self-mortifying ascetics, diehard sceptics, devoted pragmatists, artful sophists, saintly mystics and the customary miracle mongers.[4] 'Rivalries and debates were rife,' writes historian Romila Thapar. 'Audiences gathered around the new philosophers in the kutuhala-shalas—literally, the place for creating curiosity—the parks and groves on the outskirts of the towns.'[5] This was the time of the Buddha, Mahavira and the making of the Upanishads.

In the centuries ahead, the Greeks would learn much more about the Indians. A catalyst for this was Alexander of Macedon's invasion of Punjab (327–25 BCE). Alexander, after defeating the Achaemenid Persians and sacking their capital, Persepolis, crossed the Hindu Kush Mountains via the Khyber Pass and approached the plains of the Indus. News of his 50,000 seasoned warriors set off a strong self-preservation instinct in King Ambhi of Taxila, and he promptly allied with Alexander. For this act, he was called the first royal 'traitor to his country' by a twentieth-century Indian nationalist. But Ambhi had 'nought to gain by resistance except the annihilation of his illustrious city and the applause of a very remote posterity', writes historian John Keay.[6]

Continuing east, Alexander ran into King Porus and defeated him in a hard-fought battle on the banks of the Jhelam. Impressed by Porus's bravery and dignity in defeat, Alexander restored to him his kingdom and pressed on across Punjab, amassing more territory. He wanted to go all the way to the Ganga but after eight years of war, losses from their battle with Porus, and rumours of mighty armies ahead, his exhausted troops rebelled near present-day Amritsar. Alexander sulked but was forced to abort his mission.